# DarkShepherd

GTM Playbook

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## 1 Positioning

YOUR CORE POSITIONING STATEMENT

### Positioning Statement

DarkShepherd helps mid-size Shopify Plus apparel brands reduce third-party app security risk by manually monitoring app permissions, identifying excessive access before it becomes a costly breach, and guiding operators on what to fix while keeping final decisions in their control.

THE PROBLEM YOU'RE SOLVING

### Core Problem

Shopify merchants often assume Shopify itself fully protects their store, but third-party apps can accumulate overly broad permissions over time, creating hidden exposure that can lead to fraud, chargebacks, operational disruption, and potential data breach fallout. Because this risk is invisible and not routinely reviewed, stores may not act until the damage is already expensive and time-consuming to investigate.

WHY CUSTOMERS SHOULD CHOOSE YOU

### Key Differentiators

1. Shopify-specific and end-to-end: focused specifically on Shopify app-permission exposure rather than broad, generic cybersecurity services. 2. Preventative monitoring model: designed to catch risky permissions and app issues before they stack up into bigger incidents. 3. Human-in-the-loop service: manual review provides hands-on oversight and tailored recommendations at an early stage before full automation exists. 4. Merchant-controlled remediation: DarkShepherd flags issues and advises on replacement or deletion options, but the store owner keeps decision control. 5. Niche focus on Shopify

Plus apparel brands: targets merchants likely to have more apps, more complexity, and therefore higher exposure.

VS COMPETITORS

### Competitive Position

Position DarkShepherd against three alternatives: (a) generic cybersecurity vendors, by emphasizing that they are too broad and usually not built around Shopify app-permission risk; (b) analytics or performance tools, by clarifying that DarkShepherd is not about attribution or reporting mismatches but about security exposure created by app access; and (c) doing nothing / relying on Shopify, by educating prospects that Shopify secures the platform, not the unique third-party app ecosystem of each store. The strongest positioning is as a specialized preventative security layer for Shopify Plus merchants with heavy app stacks, especially apparel brands.

OBJECTIONS TO ADDRESS

### Key Objections

1. 'Shopify already protects us.' Response: clarify that Shopify protects the platform, but third-party app permissions inside an individual store can still create exposure that merchants must monitor themselves. 2. 'This doesn’t feel urgent.' Response: frame the cost of inaction around fraud, chargebacks, lost product, investigation time, customer notification burden, and the compounding effect of unmanaged app access over time; tie messaging to platform changes and upcoming ecosystem deadlines where relevant. 3. 'We’ve never had a breach, so why pay now?' Response: position DarkShepherd as preventative monitoring that is cheaper and less disruptive than backtracking after a security incident. 4. 'We already have internal ecommerce or engineering staff.' Response: emphasize specialized review of Shopify app permissions and independent oversight that internal teams may not prioritize consistently. 5. 'The value is unclear for the price.' Response: make the risk more concrete with quantified examples, explain the onboarding audit plus ongoing monitoring, and show how even one avoided fraud or breach-related incident can outweigh the fee. 6. 'I’m not sure I trust a new vendor in an unfamiliar category.' Response: lead with education, use workshops/webinars and early-access or pilot offers, and build credibility through niche expertise, clear monitoring processes, and specific examples of risky permission patterns.

Unlock ML Grow Plan →

## 2 Target Personas

**Launch priority.** Target the Shopify Plus apparel ecommerce operator first because the founder explicitly narrowed the market to Shopify Plus stores, said apparel brands tend to have more apps and therefore more risk/complexity, and these businesses are more likely than smaller stores to afford a setup fee plus ongoing monitoring. This is also the segment the founder already knows how to identify using BuiltWith, Hunter.io, and LinkedIn.

### The Shopify Plus Apparel Operator

A decision-maker or ecommerce lead at a Shopify Plus apparel store with a large app stack.

- Not discussed
- **Pain:** Their store uses many third-party Shopify apps, and app permissions may be broader than necessary, creating risk around unauthorized write access, potential data breaches, and hard-to-trace backend issues that stack over time.
- **Wants:** Preventative monitoring of backend app permissions, visibility into risky apps, education on what is happening, and recommendations on whether to remove or replace problematic apps while keeping final control over decisions.
- *"Too many Shopify apps, too little visibility — know which permissions put your apparel store at risk before the problem compounds."*
- LinkedIn, direct email via Hunter.io, Shopify Plus store websites identified through BuiltWith, and apparel-focused Shopify Plus companies in the US

### The Ecommerce VP Needing Risk Clarity

A VP of Ecommerce or similar ecommerce leader responsible for store operations and technology oversight.

- Not discussed
- **Pain:** They may assume Shopify itself covers store-level security, while in reality third-party apps can introduce permission and data exposure risks they are not actively monitoring.
- **Wants:** Clear explanation of store-level risk, quantified business impact, proactive alerts, and a trusted specialist who can review the backend regularly and explain issues from A to Z without requiring the leader to investigate everything personally.
- *"Shopify protects the platform — but who is watching the third-party apps inside your store?"*

LinkedIn, direct outbound email, company websites of Shopify Plus brands, and potential webinar or roundtable invitations aimed at ecommerce leaders

### The Chargeback-Stressed Store Owner

A Shopify store owner dealing with fraud, chargebacks, and frustration over unclear backend causes.

Not discussed

**Pain:** They experience fraud or chargebacks and can lose both revenue and product, but may not understand whether backend app permissions or third-party access contributed to the issue.

**Wants:** Help identifying what is happening in the backend, early warning before issues escalate, guidance on risky apps, and a path to reduce losses tied to fraud or security-related store problems.

*"When fraud hits, the cost is more than the refund — stop hidden app risks before they turn into lost product and chargebacks."*

Reddit and Shopify-related subreddits where merchants discuss chargebacks and fraud, LinkedIn, and direct outreach to Shopify store operators



## 3 Data Sourcing Criteria

CONSUMER AUDIENCE — WHERE TO FIND THEM

Primary audience sources:

1. LinkedIn:
  - Search for Shopify Plus ecommerce operators at US-based apparel brands.
  - Use company pages and employee search for titles like VP Ecommerce, Head of Ecommerce, Ecommerce Manager, Director of Ecommerce, Shopify Manager, Digital Operations Manager, and Ecommerce Operations Manager.
  - Follow and engage with posts discussing Shopify app stacks, fraud, checkout issues, chargebacks, backend problems, data exposure, and operational risk.

- Create and monitor conversations around Shopify app permissions, third-party app risk, chargebacks, and June 30 Shopify script/app ecosystem changes.

2. Direct company sourcing:
   - Shopify Plus apparel brand websites in the US.
   - Use BuiltWith to identify stores running Shopify Plus and to inspect app stacks / technology layers.
   - Prioritize apparel brands with larger app stacks and visible technology complexity.
   - Use Hunter.io to find direct emails for ecommerce leaders and operators at those brands.
3. Reddit:
   - Shopify-related subreddits where merchants discuss chargebacks, fraud, suspicious activity, app issues, and backend confusion.
   - Ecommerce and DTC-related Reddit communities where store owners vent about fraud losses, customer disputes, operational issues, and platform/plugin problems.
   - Focus on threads where merchants describe unexplained chargebacks, fraud spikes, suspicious app behavior, or uncertainty about what is happening in the backend.
4. Educational/event-led sourcing:
   - Webinar, roundtable, or invite-only discussion lists aimed at Shopify Plus apparel operators and ecommerce leaders.
   - Prospects sourced from outbound lists can be funneled into a short educational session on third-party app permissions, app-risk monitoring, and Shopify ecosystem changes.
5. Owned audience building:
   - Newsletter signup audience built from LinkedIn educational content and webinar landing pages.
   - Lead magnet or research-report landing pages focused on Shopify app permission risk, fraud, chargebacks, and third-party exposure.
6. Secondary research sources mentioned or implied:
   - BuiltWith technology profiles for ecommerce brands.
   - Public company/store websites to verify vertical fit, brand size, and ecommerce complexity.
   - Potential forums or communities for Shopify merchants were suggested, but no specific named non-Reddit communities were discussed.

### Seller signals to look for

- Company is running Shopify Plus
- Company is an apparel / clothing brand
- Brand appears mid-size and likely able to afford a setup fee plus recurring monitoring
- Company has a large or complex Shopify app stack based on BuiltWith or similar tooling
- Store shows multiple third-party apps or layered technology tools, suggesting permission sprawl risk
- Prospect title is tied to ecommerce operations, store management, or ecommerce leadership
- Prospect engages with or posts about Shopify backend issues, app issues, analytics mismatch, checkout issues, or operational complexity
- Prospect expresses frustration about chargebacks, fraud, suspicious orders, or unexplained store issues
- Prospect discusses third-party tools, integrations, scripts, or upcoming Shopify ecosystem changes
- Prospect indicates belief that Shopify itself handles all security, creating an education opportunity

- Store spends meaningfully on ecommerce technology, implying multiple tools and more exposure
- Prospect opens outbound emails and interacts with LinkedIn content, even if they do not reply yet
- Prospect joins or shows interest in a webinar, roundtable, or educational session about app permissions or store risk
- Merchant posts publicly asking what to do about fraud, chargebacks, or backend confusion
- Merchant mentions considering removing apps, replacing apps, or cleaning up store backend complexity

### Exclude

- Small Shopify stores with limited budgets — exclude because founder stated smaller stores are less able to afford the setup fee and monthly monitoring
- Non-Shopify stores — exclude because the offer is Shopify-specific
- Standard Shopify merchants as initial outreach priority — deprioritize because founder explicitly wants Shopify Plus first
- Non-apparel brands in the first wave — exclude initially to keep messaging narrow and because apparel brands tend to have more apps and more complexity
- Companies with very small app stacks — exclude because the pain is less acute and the value proposition is weaker
- Prospects outside ecommerce/store operations roles — exclude because they are less likely to understand or own the problem
- Very early-stage brands or solo merchants — exclude because they have other urgent priorities and lower willingness to pay
- Generic analytics buyers looking for reporting reconciliation only — exclude because DarkShepherd is not an analytics tool
- Security teams at very large enterprises outside the Shopify-store operator context — exclude initially because the motion is designed around ecommerce operators and leaders, not enterprise security procurement
- People looking for fully automated self-serve software only — exclude if they clearly reject a manual/human-in-the-loop service model
- Prospects with no visible Shopify Plus confirmation and no evidence of app complexity — exclude to avoid broad unqualified outreach

LINKEDIN SALES NAVIGATOR

## Sales Navigator Search Criteria

LinkedIn Sales Navigator search criteria:
- Job Title (Required): VP of Ecommerce; Head of Ecommerce; Director of Ecommerce; Ecommerce Manager; Ecommerce Operations Manager; Digital Operations Manager; Shopify Manager; Shopify Plus Manager; Director of Digital Commerce; Ecommerce Director; Store Operations Manager
- Company Headcount (Required): 50-100 employees as core starting range; optionally test adjacent bands 11-50 and 101-200 for comparison
- Industry (Required): Apparel & Fashion; Retail Apparel and Fashion; Consumer Goods; Retail; Luxury Goods &

Jewelry (only if Shopify Plus apparel-adjacent); Sporting Goods (only if apparel-led ecommerce)
- Geography (Required): United States; prioritize New York metro first if narrowing is needed; optional radius targeting around New York City for first tests
- Keywords in profile: Shopify; Shopify Plus; ecommerce; direct-to-consumer; DTC; digital commerce; online store; retention; chargebacks; fraud; operations; merchandising; storefront; checkout; apps
- Seniority: Manager; Director; VP; Head
- Years in role: 1-10 years; prioritize 1-5 years in role for operators likely close to current problems
- Exclude — Company: Very large marketplaces, agencies, software vendors, or generic cybersecurity firms where the person is not a merchant-side operator; avoid major enterprise retailers if the sales cycle is likely too complex for current stage
- Exclude — Title: CEO; Founder; Owner at large organizations; CTO; CIO; CISO; President; overly senior executives who are less likely to engage early on without internal validation

# 4 Outreach Channels

Ranked by priority — start here, expand based on what converts

### 1 Direct outreach to Shopify Plus apparel brands — cold email + manual LinkedIn follow-up

Build a tightly defined prospect list of US-based Shopify Plus apparel brands, ideally with 50–100 employees or clear signals of operational maturity. Prioritize brands with many installed apps and higher technology spend using tools like BuiltWith, store app detectors, company websites, and Hunter.io. Rewrite outreach so it is short, urgent, and educational rather than open-ended. Lead with a concrete risk signal: excessive app permissions, third-party exposure, checkout/script changes, chargeback/fraud risk, or costly remediation. Use one simple CTA only: invite them to a 15–20 minute discovery call or a short private roundtable. Follow initial email with a LinkedIn profile visit, connection request, and short message referencing the same issue. Keep outreach highly personalized for the top 20–30 accounts each week instead of broad-volume sends.

*This is the highest-priority channel because it directly reaches the exact buyers DarkShepherd wants: Shopify Plus ecommerce leaders at apparel brands. The founder already has the basic workflow in place with Hunter.io, BuiltWith-style research, and some sending experience, so this can start today with almost no new budget. It also fits the business model: a higher-touch, education-heavy service that likely needs a call before purchase. It ranks above everything else because it is the fastest path to customer conversations, validation, and first revenue, even before the messaging is fully optimized.*

### 2 Founder-led LinkedIn thought leadership — organic posts + comments + targeted connection requests

Use the founder's personal LinkedIn as the main organic credibility engine. Continue the educational post series, but sharpen each post around one concrete risk, one consequence, and one takeaway for Shopify Plus apparel operators. Post 3 times per week is enough if quality is high. Add polls, short case-style posts, ‘did you know’ permission-risk breakdowns, and deadline-driven posts tied to Shopify platform changes. Do not just broadcast: spend time each week connecting with VP Ecommerce, Ecommerce Managers, Operations leaders, and Shopify consultants/agencies serving apparel brands. Comment thoughtfully on their posts and on relevant ecommerce/security discussions. Use DMs sparingly after engagement, with invitations to a short roundtable or free assessment.

*LinkedIn is ranked second because the target customers are reachable there, the founder already has a profile and is posting, and this channel supports the education-heavy nature of the offer. Since DarkShepherd is selling a problem many merchants do not yet see as urgent, founder credibility matters. Organic LinkedIn also has near-zero budget requirements. It is not ranked first because organic content alone is unlikely to generate enough immediate pipeline without direct outreach, especially from a low-trust starting point.*

3

### Private educational webinar / roundtable — invite-only event for Shopify Plus apparel operators

Create a simple landing page for a 20–30 minute invite-only session aimed at Shopify Plus apparel brands. Position it as a practical briefing, not a sales webinar. Example themes: app permission sprawl, hidden third-party risks in Shopify stacks, what changes after Shopify script transitions, or how ecommerce teams should review installed apps. Invite cold prospects, LinkedIn connections, and any interested operators from communities. Keep the format lightweight: 10 minutes of founder insight, 10 minutes of examples, 10 minutes of discussion. End with a clear next step: free beta assessment, free app-permission review, or a short discovery call.

*This ranks third because it is a strong bridge between awareness and sales for a product that needs education and trust-building. It gives the founder a scalable way to start customer conversations and validate willingness to pay. It also repurposes well into content, lead capture, and follow-up. It is ranked below direct outreach and LinkedIn because it depends on those channels to drive attendance; by itself, a webinar has no audience yet.*

4

### Shopify / ecommerce communities — Reddit, forums, Slack groups, Facebook groups, and niche operator communities

Systematically join and participate in the places where Shopify operators already discuss problems: Shopify-related subreddits, ecommerce operator groups, DTC communities, Slack groups, and founder forums. Start by listening and documenting repeated pain themes such as chargebacks, fraud, app overload, checkout issues, and tech stack complexity. Build karma/credibility where needed before promoting anything. Ask transparent research questions, run simple polls, respond helpfully to relevant threads, and share mini educational breakdowns. The immediate goal is not to sell; it is to gather language, objections, use cases, and potential beta users.

*This channel ranks fourth because it is low-cost and useful for discovery, messaging validation, and early trust-building. It is especially valuable since the founder currently has little first-hand customer access and needs more interviews. However, it is lower priority than outreach and LinkedIn because access can be slow,* *rules may limit promotion, and conversion to sales is less direct. It is best used to sharpen positioning and uncover warm opportunities rather than as the main acquisition engine.*

5

### Lead magnet + email capture on website/newsletter — organic nurture

Create one concrete downloadable resource tailored to the niche, such as a ‘Shopify Plus Apparel App Permission Risk Checklist,’ ‘Third-Party App Review Worksheet,’ or ‘Pre-migration Security Review for Shopify Plus Teams.’ Put it behind a simple email capture page with one CTA. Use this asset in cold outreach, LinkedIn posts, webinar invitations, and community discussions. Start a weekly newsletter only after there is something useful to send: short practical insights, app-risk checks, examples from public stores, and upcoming platform-change implications. Keep sign-up friction low and messaging highly specific.

*This ranks fifth because it helps convert attention into owned audience and supports longer sales cycles, but it is not an immediate acquisition channel on its own. Right now the founder has no list and limited traffic, so a newsletter by itself will not drive demand. Still, it is worth setting up early because it strengthens every other channel and gives prospects a lower-commitment next step than booking a call.*

## 5 First 30 Days

Week-by-week execution — supply side first, buyers follow

WEEK 1

### Foundation — Set up infrastructure and geographic focus

→ Narrow the initial market to one tightly defined segment: US-based Shopify Plus apparel brands with 50–100 employees, prioritizing New York area brands first if a geographic tie-breaker is needed. Build a starter list of 40 target companies using BuiltWith, company websites, and LinkedIn.

→ Create a simple prospect tracker in a spreadsheet or free CRM with these columns: company, website, Shopify Plus confirmed, apparel confirmed, estimated employee count, app-stack complexity notes, technology-spend notes, target contact name, title, email, LinkedIn URL, outreach status, last touch date, and next step.

→ Rewrite the website hero and core copy so it emphasizes consequences instead of vague risk. Update the homepage and one landing page to clearly state: third-party app permissions can create hidden store-level risk, Shopify secures the platform not each store’s app stack, and unmanaged access can contribute to fraud, chargebacks, investigation time, and customer-notification burden.

→ Build one focused landing page with one CTA only: register for a 20–30 minute private briefing for Shopify Plus apparel operators. Suggested topic: 'Hidden Third-Party App Risk in Shopify Plus Apparel Stores.' Include 3 bullets on what attendees will learn and a short form collecting name, work email, company, and title.

- Create one lightweight lead magnet that can be finished quickly: a 1-page 'Shopify Plus Apparel App Permission Risk Checklist' with 7–10 review points. Add it to the website behind an email capture form and use the same asset in email and LinkedIn outreach.
- Draft 2 outreach sequences before sending anything: one email sequence for webinar/briefing invites and one LinkedIn message sequence for connection + follow-up. Keep each message short, specific, and single-CTA only. Remove open-ended questions and replace them with direct asks like 'Would you like an invite?'

**Goal: Finish core infrastructure and produce a qualified list of 40 target accounts, 40 matched contacts, 1 webinar landing page, and 1 downloadable checklist by the end of the week.**

WEEK 2

### Activate — Start outreach, make first contacts

- Send personalized cold emails to 20 prospects from the week 1 list, focusing on VP Ecommerce, Head of Ecommerce, Director of Ecommerce, Ecommerce Manager, and Shopify Manager roles at Shopify Plus apparel brands. Personalize the first line using one visible signal such as large app stack, Shopify Plus confirmation, or technology complexity.
- Send LinkedIn connection requests to the same 20 prospects within 24 hours of the email. Use a short note such as 'I'm hosting a short private briefing for Shopify Plus apparel operators on third-party app permission risk—happy to send the invite if useful.'
- Publish 3 founder-led LinkedIn posts this week: one on 'Shopify protects the platform, not every app in your store,' one on permission sprawl from multiple apps, and one on fraud/chargeback consequences when backend risk goes unmanaged. End each post with a soft CTA to comment 'checklist' or 'invite' for the resource.
- Comment meaningfully on 10 LinkedIn posts from ecommerce leaders, Shopify operators, or DTC apparel brands discussing backend issues, app tools, fraud, chargebacks, checkout, or Shopify changes. Comments should add insight, not pitch.
- Join 3 relevant Reddit or ecommerce communities and spend 20–30 minutes across the week documenting recurring pain language around chargebacks, fraud, suspicious orders, app overload, and backend confusion. Save at least 10 direct quotes or paraphrased pain statements for future copy.
- Follow up with the first email cohort using a second-touch message 3–4 days later offering either the checklist or the private briefing invite, rather than pushing directly for a sales call.

**Goal: Reach at least 20 qualified prospects by email, send 20 LinkedIn connection requests, publish 3 LinkedIn posts, and secure at least 5 total positive signals such as replies, accepted connections, checklist requests, or briefing interest.**

WEEK 3

### Convert — Platform launch announcement, drive signups

→ Announce the private briefing publicly on LinkedIn and through direct outreach. Frame it as invite-only for Shopify Plus apparel operators and position it as an educational session, not a sales webinar. Send invites to 20 new prospects and re-invite the warmest 10 contacts from week 2.

→ Run one 20–30 minute live briefing this week, even if attendance is small. Suggested format: 10 minutes on why app permissions become risky over time, 10 minutes on common hidden exposure patterns in Shopify stacks, and 5–10 minutes Q&A. End with one CTA: apply for a free beta app-permission review.

→ Create a simple beta offer page for a limited number of early users. Position it as a founder-led manual review for Shopify Plus apparel stores, limited to 3–5 brands, in exchange for feedback and a testimonial if the engagement is valuable.

→ Send follow-up emails and LinkedIn messages to every registrant and attendee within 24 hours of the briefing. Offer 2 specific next steps only: a 15-minute discovery call or a free beta review application.

→ Publish 2 additional LinkedIn posts based on what came up during outreach and the briefing, for example: '3 misconceptions Shopify Plus teams have about third-party app access' and 'What fraud/chargeback conversations reveal about hidden backend complexity.'

→ Refine the homepage, landing page, and outreach copy using real language gathered from prospect replies, Reddit pain points, and any briefing questions. Specifically strengthen consequence-based messaging around fraud, chargebacks, lost product, investigation effort, and vendor/app visibility.

**Goal: Get at least 8 briefing registrations, hold 1 live session, and secure 3 discovery calls or beta review applications by the end of the week.**

WEEK 4

## Pipeline — First conversions, buyer acquisition begins

→ Hold discovery calls with all warm prospects and use a consistent script: current Shopify app stack size, who owns app installation, whether permissions are reviewed, recent fraud/chargeback or backend issues, current belief about Shopify security coverage, and willingness to test a manual monitoring service.

→ Offer a limited beta package to the most qualified 3 prospects: discounted or free initial review in exchange for fast feedback, a case study conversation, and permission to use anonymized findings in future marketing. Keep the offer time-boxed to create urgency.

→ Send a second wave of outreach to 20 additional Shopify Plus apparel prospects using the improved messaging from weeks 2–3. Mention the briefing insights or checklist as proof of relevance, not generic sales copy.

→ Build a simple one-page call summary/template so after each conversation you log objections, buyer language, urgency level, number of apps, interest in setup fee, and whether the prospect prefers education, checklist, audit, or monitoring. Use these notes to sharpen pricing and packaging.

→ Launch the first email newsletter only if there are subscribers from the checklist or briefing. Send one short issue summarizing 3 warning signs of risky app access and include one CTA to apply for the beta review.

→ At the end of the week, review the 30-day funnel metrics: list size, emails sent, open rates, reply rates, LinkedIn connection acceptance, briefing registrations, calls booked, and beta applications. Use this to decide whether to stay focused on apparel/NY or broaden slightly to more US Shopify Plus apparel brands.

**Goal: Complete at least 3 discovery calls, generate 1–2 beta review starts or serious pilot conversations, and finish the month with a repeatable outreach + follow-up process.**

# 6 Content Calendar

WEEK 1

**MONDAY**

EDUCATION

LinkedIn founder post: "Shopify secures the platform — not every third-party app inside your store". Explain the difference between Shopify platform security and store-level app permission risk for Shopify Plus apparel brands.

LinkedIn

**TUESDAY**

BUILD-IN-PUBLIC

Founder journey post: "Why I narrowed DarkShepherd to Shopify Plus apparel brands". Share the reasoning: apparel stores tend to run more apps, have more backend complexity, and likely feel permission sprawl more acutely.

LinkedIn

**WEDNESDAY**

COMMUNITY

Join Shopify and ecommerce Reddit threads discussing chargebacks, fraud, suspicious orders, and app overload. Add a helpful comment summarizing how backend app access can be one hidden factor merchants overlook, without mentioning the product.

Reddit

**THURSDAY**

TIPS

Practical checklist post: "3 signs your Shopify app stack may be riskier than it looks" — too many installed apps, unclear write permissions, and nobody regularly reviewing backend access.

LinkedIn

**FRIDAY**

RECAP

Weekly founder recap: summarize the top 3 pain patterns seen this week from outreach and community research, such as chargebacks, confusion around app permissions, and the belief that Shopify handles everything automatically.

LinkedIn

WEEK 2

MONDAY

OBJECTIONS

Objection-handling post: "We already use Shopify Plus — isn't that enough?" Address the misconception that Shopify Plus alone covers third-party app permission exposure inside the store.

LinkedIn

TUESDAY

WEBINAR/EVENT

Promote a short private briefing: "Hidden Third-Party App Risk in Shopify Plus Apparel Stores". Invite VP Ecommerce, Ecommerce Managers, and Shopify operators to a 20–30 minute educational session.

LinkedIn

WEDNESDAY

COMMUNITY

Start a transparent discussion thread in a LinkedIn post asking ecommerce operators: "How often does your team review installed Shopify app permissions?" Offer multiple-choice style options to make replies easy.

LinkedIn

THURSDAY

CTA

Early access offer: invite Shopify Plus apparel brands to request the free 1-page "App Permission Risk Checklist" in exchange for email signup.

LinkedIn

FRIDAY

BUILD-IN-PUBLIC

Founder update: share the process of manually reviewing app permissions today and what the future automation vision looks like, while emphasizing that the current service is hands-on and founder-led.

LinkedIn

WEEK 3

MONDAY

EDUCATION

Educational post: "Read access vs write access in Shopify apps — why that difference matters". Use a simple ecommerce example like cart or customer data to explain why excessive write permissions increase risk.

LinkedIn

TUESDAY

PLATFORM UPDATE

Share a workflow preview: a mockup or screenshot of how DarkShepherd's manual monitoring process works today — onboarding review, weekly checks, flagged app, and merchant-controlled recommendation flow.

LinkedIn

WEDNESDAY

COMMUNITY

Answer merchant questions in Reddit or Shopify forums around fraud, backend confusion, or app cleanup. Focus on clarifying what signals suggest a store should review third-party app permissions.

Reddit

THURSDAY

WEBINAR/EVENT

Live session day: post a same-day reminder for the private briefing, positioning it as a practical, no-pitch discussion for Shopify Plus apparel operators navigating app sprawl and ecosystem changes.

LinkedIn

FRIDAY

RECAP

Event recap: summarize 3 takeaways from the briefing, such as common misconceptions about Shopify security, why app sprawl compounds over time, and what operators should review first.

LinkedIn

WEEK 4

MONDAY

OBJECTIONS

Objection post: "We've never had a breach, so why pay for monitoring now?" Reframe the service as preventative review that is cheaper and easier than backtracking after fraud, chargebacks, or a security incident.

LinkedIn

TUESDAY

SOCIAL PROOF

Milestone post: share a founder credibility update such as first briefing attendees, number of stores researched, or number of conversations started with Shopify Plus operators.

LinkedIn

WEDNESDAY

TIPS

Tactical post: "If you run a Shopify Plus apparel store, review these 5 things before adding one more app" — permissions, data access, ownership, overlap, replacement risk, and monitoring responsibility.

LinkedIn

THURSDAY

CTA

Beta invitation: "I'm opening a limited number of founder-led app-permission reviews for Shopify Plus apparel brands". Invite qualified operators to apply for early access or book a short discovery call.

LinkedIn

FRIDAY

RECAP

Month-end recap: what DarkShepherd learned from 4 weeks of talking to Shopify Plus apparel operators, including messaging that resonated, objections heard most often, and what is being improved next.

LinkedIn

# 7 Outreach Copy

### LinkedIn DM — customer outreach

The Shopify Plus Apparel Operator at a US-based apparel brand with a large app stack

Hi [First Name] — I came across [Brand] and noticed you're running Shopify Plus in apparel, which usually means a pretty layered app stack.

I'm Jin, founder of DarkShepherd. We help mid-size Shopify Plus apparel brands reduce third-party app security risk by manually monitoring app permissions, identifying excessive access before it becomes a costly breach, and guiding operators on what to fix while keeping final decisions in their control.

I'm reaching out because a lot of teams I research seem to assume Shopify covers everything at the store level, when in reality third-party apps can quietly keep broader permissions than they really need.

Not pitching you here — I'm speaking with a small number of Shopify Plus apparel operators to understand how teams currently review app permissions, backend access, and app cleanup.

Curious: does someone at [Brand] actively review installed app permissions today, or does that mostly get handled ad hoc?

*CTA: Reply with how your team currently handles app permission reviews, or if useful, I can send over a short checklist.*

Copy message

### Email — vendor/partner outreach

Shopify agencies, Shopify consultants, ecommerce operations partners, and app ecosystem service providers working with Shopify Plus apparel brands

**Subject:** Possible partner fit for Shopify Plus apparel clients

Hi [First Name],

I'm Jin, founder of DarkShepherd.

We help mid-size Shopify Plus apparel brands reduce third-party app security risk by manually monitoring app permissions, identifying excessive access before it becomes a costly breach, and guiding operators on what to fix while keeping final decisions in their control.

I'm reaching out because partners like [Agency/Company Name] often help merchants add, optimize, or replace apps — but app permission sprawl and backend access risk usually aren't being reviewed in a dedicated way.

That seems like an opportunity for mutual value:
- you stay focused on implementation, growth, and store performance
- DarkShepherd can serve as a specialized review layer for risky app access
- your clients get more visibility without adding another broad cybersecurity vendor

I'm currently focused on Shopify Plus apparel brands in the US, especially merchants with larger app stacks.

Would you be open to a short 15-minute conversation to see whether a referral or co-education relationship could make sense? Even if now isn't the right time, I'd value comparing notes on what your clients are dealing with around app complexity, fraud, chargebacks, and store-level risk.

*CTA: Open to a 15-minute intro call next week to explore a light referral or webinar partnership?*

Copy message

### Community post — LinkedIn/Facebook group/Reddit

VPs of Ecommerce, Ecommerce Managers, Shopify Managers, and chargeback-stressed Shopify store operators at Shopify Plus apparel brands

Hi everyone — I'm Jin, founder of DarkShepherd.

DarkShepherd helps mid-size Shopify Plus apparel brands reduce third-party app security risk by manually monitoring app permissions, identifying excessive access before it becomes a costly breach, and guiding operators on what to fix while keeping final decisions in their control.

I've been researching a pattern that keeps coming up with Shopify Plus stores:
- teams install more and more third-party apps over time
- permissions are often broader than expected
- Shopify is assumed to cover all of it, even though Shopify secures the platform, not each store's unique app stack
- when something goes wrong, merchants can end up dealing with fraud, chargebacks, lost product, investigation time, and a messy backtracking process

I'm not here to hard-sell anything.

Right now I'm putting together a short private briefing and a simple checklist for Shopify Plus apparel operators on how to think about app permission sprawl, third-party exposure, and what to review first.

If you run ecommerce, store ops, or Shopify management for an apparel brand, I'd love to learn:
1. How often does your team review installed app permissions?
2. Do you feel confident you know which apps have write access vs read access?
3. Have fraud, chargebacks, or backend issues ever made you question your app stack?

If there's interest, I'll share the checklist here and invite a few operators into the first briefing session.

*CTA: Comment 'checklist' or 'invite' if you want the resource or want to join the private briefing.*

Copy message

# 8 CRM & Pipeline

MANAGE YOUR PIPELINE

### Seller Lead Pipeline

Track every lead from first contact to conversion.

TARGETED

**A Shopify Plus apparel prospect has been identified and added to the CRM, but no outreach has been sent yet. This is the research and list-building stage.**

*Using BuiltWith + Hunter, Jin identifies a US-based Shopify Plus apparel brand with many third-party apps and adds the VP of Ecommerce to the CRM.*

CONTACTED

**Initial outreach has been sent through email, LinkedIn, or an invite to a roundtable/webinar/assessment. The lead has not meaningfully engaged yet.**

*A cold email is sent about Shopify app permission risk and an invitation to a 30-minute educational session.*

ENGAGED

**The prospect has shown buying signal or learning signal, such as opening multiple emails, clicking a link, replying, accepting a LinkedIn request, registering for a webinar, or requesting more information.**

*A prospect replies asking how app permission monitoring works, or signs up for an educational webinar on Shopify app risk.*

DISCOVERY / AUDIT CONVERSATION

**A live conversation is scheduled or completed to understand the store setup, app stack, pain points, urgency, and fit for a manual monitoring offer or free pilot.**

*Jin speaks with an ecommerce manager who has 30+ apps installed and is worried about chargebacks and app permissions.*

PILOT / PROPOSAL

**The lead is qualified and has received a paid proposal or free/discounted beta pilot offer. Commercial terms, scope, and next steps are being discussed.**

*A prospect receives a proposal with a $1,000-$1,500 setup fee and monthly monitoring, or a 14-day beta monitoring offer.*

WON / LOST

**The opportunity is closed. Mark as Won if they become a paying customer or active pilot user; mark as Lost if they decline, go silent after follow-ups, or are not a fit.**

*Won: a Shopify Plus apparel brand starts onboarding. Lost: the prospect says security is not a priority this quarter.*

## Vendor Pipeline

POTENTIAL PARTNER IDENTIFIED

**A possible referral or distribution partner has been identified. For DarkShepherd, likely partner types include Shopify consultants, ecommerce agencies, fraud consultants, cybersecurity advisors, or Shopify ecosystem experts.**

*Jin identifies a Shopify agency serving mid-market apparel brands that could refer stores needing app permission monitoring.*

PARTNER OUTREACH SENT

**Initial contact has been made to explore collaboration, referral, co-hosted education, or access to target customers.**

*An outreach message is sent proposing a co-hosted webinar on third-party app risk for Shopify Plus brands.*

PARTNER DISCUSSION

**A conversation is underway to assess fit, audience overlap, referral structure, and joint go-to-market opportunities.**

*A Shopify consultant agrees to discuss introducing DarkShepherd to apparel clients with large app stacks.*

PARTNERSHIP AGREED

**Both sides agree on a lightweight arrangement such as referrals, co-marketing, webinar collaboration, or pilot introductions.**

*A fraud prevention advisor agrees to refer clients in exchange for reciprocal referrals or a revenue share.*

ACTIVE PARTNER

**The partner is actively sending leads, collaborating on content, or participating in joint events.**

*A Shopify-focused agency is now introducing DarkShepherd to clients and co-promoting a monthly educational session.*

### Key CRM Fields to Set Up

Seller Lead CRM Fields\n1. Company name\n2. Website URL\n3. Contact full name\n4. Job title / role (e.g. VP Ecommerce, Ecommerce Manager, Founder)\n5. Email address\n6. LinkedIn profile URL\n7. Company location / geography\n8. Industry / sub-niche (prioritize apparel)\n9. Shopify plan status (Shopify vs Shopify Plus)\n10. Estimated company size (employees)\n11. Estimated app stack size / complexity\n12. Tech notes from BuiltWith / research\n13. Source channel (Hunter, LinkedIn, webinar, referral, Reddit insight, website inbound)\n14. Current pipeline stage\n15. Date added to CRM\n16. First outreach date\n17. Last contact date\n18. Next follow-up date\n19. Outreach channel used (email, LinkedIn, call, webinar invite)\n20. Engagement signal (opened, clicked, replied, booked, attended)\n21. Key pain point observed (chargebacks, app permissions, compliance concern, too many apps, unclear ownership)\n22. Urgency trigger (upcoming Shopify/script change, recent fraud issue, recent chargebacks, audit need)\n23. Qualification status (good fit / poor fit / unclear)\n24. Offer type discussed (discovery call, free audit, beta, pilot, paid setup + monitoring)\n25. Budget sensitivity / pricing reaction\n26. Main objection raised\n27. Decision-maker identified? (yes/no + name if different)\n28. Notes / conversation summary\n29. Outcome (won, lost, nurture, no response)\n30. Lost reason / nurture reason\n\nMinimum solo-founder version for seller leads:\n- Company name\n- Contact name\n- Email\n- LinkedIn\n- Segment (Shopify Plus / apparel / geography)\n- Stage\n- Last contact date\n- Next follow-up date\n- Pain point / objection\n- Notes\n\nVendor / Partner CRM Fields\n1. Partner company name\n2. Partner type (Shopify agency, consultant, cybersecurity advisor, fraud expert, ecommerce community, app ecosystem contact)\n3. Contact full name\n4. Role / title\n5. Email\n6. LinkedIn / website\n7. Audience fit / why this partner matters\n8. Source / how identified\n9. Current partner stage\n10. Date added\n11. First outreach date\n12. Last contact date\n13. Next follow-up date\n14. Proposed collaboration type (referrals, co-webinar, content swap, affiliate, introductions)\n15. Terms discussed\n16. Number of leads referred / expected\n17. Active status\n18. Notes\n\nMinimum solo-founder version for partners:\n- Partner company\n- Contact name\n- Partner type\n- Stage\n- Last contact date\n- Next follow-up date\n- Collaboration idea\n- Notes

## 9 KPIs & Metrics

The numbers that tell you if your first 30 days are working

QUALIFIED LEAD CAPTURES AND REGISTRATIONS

## 10-15 total by Day 30, made up of at least 8 private briefing registrations and 2-7 checklist or beta-interest signups from qualified Shopify Plus apparel prospects

Measure how many qualified people from the target niche take a low-commitment action: register for the private briefing, request the checklist, or submit interest in a beta review. This is the closest early-stage equivalent to platform signups for DarkShepherd, since the offer is still education-led and not a self-serve product. At this stage, the founder mainly needs proof that the messaging can turn cold attention into identifiable prospects, not mass volume. If 10-15 qualified signups happen in 30 days with limited founder time, that suggests the niche and positioning are resonating enough to keep investing in outreach and education.

> **If below target:** Narrow the audience further instead of broadening it. Focus only on US Shopify Plus apparel brands with visible app complexity and 50-100 employees. Replace generic website CTAs with one landing page and one CTA only. Make the offer more concrete and urgent by leading with consequences such as fraud, chargebacks, investigation burden, and third-party write access risk. Test two lead magnets or event angles: one around app permissions, one around Shopify ecosystem/script changes.

CORE ACTION COMPLETION: DISCOVERY CONVERSATIONS WITH TARGET BUYERS

## 3-5 completed discovery calls by Day 30

For DarkShepherd, the core user action is not app usage yet; it is a live discovery conversation with a qualified ecommerce operator or leader. Because this is a high-trust, education-heavy service, calls are the clearest sign that prospects understand the problem enough to invest time. In the first 30 days, 3-5 calls is realistic for a solo founder with another job and no existing customer base. If the founder cannot get calls, it likely means the pain is still being framed too vaguely or the CTA is too large for cold outreach.

> **If below target:** Stop asking open-ended questions in outreach and shift to easier CTAs such as 'Want the checklist?' or 'Would you like an invite?'. Use the private briefing as the bridge to calls. Shorten emails, personalize the first line with a specific app-stack signal, and add LinkedIn follow-up to every email touch. If people engage but do not book, add a founder-led free beta review application as the next step instead of asking directly for a paid conversation.

PARTNER PIPELINE ACTIVATION

## 5 partner outreach conversations started and 1-2 active partner opportunities identified by Day 30

Measure how many relevant partners enter conversation, such as Shopify agencies, Shopify consultants, fraud advisors, or ecommerce operators with access to the same buyer. This matters because DarkShepherd is entering a low-awareness category where borrowed trust can materially improve response rates. In month one, the goal is not a formal channel program; it is simply validating whether credible partners see the problem and are willing to co-educate or refer. Even one promising partner path can make future distribution much easier.

> **If below target:** Shift the partner pitch away from selling monitoring and toward mutual education value. Offer a co-branded webinar, a checklist for their clients, or a short conversation about common Shopify app-risk patterns. Prioritize partners already serving Shopify Plus apparel brands instead of generic cybersecurity contacts. If outreach is ignored, use LinkedIn commenting and warm interaction before sending the ask.

POSITIVE OUTREACH RESPONSE RATE

## 8%-12% positive response rate by Day 30 from qualified outbound, defined as replies, accepted briefing invites, checklist requests, or LinkedIn DMs that continue the conversation

Measure the share of outreach that generates meaningful engagement, not just opens. Since the founder already saw opens without replies, response quality is a better health metric than open rate. For an unproven niche service sold via cold outbound, an 8%-12% positive response rate from a tightly qualified list is a realistic early signal that the message is specific enough and the target segment is relevant. Anything much lower suggests that prospects either do not understand the risk, do not see urgency, or do not trust the framing yet.

> **If below target:** Rewrite the first-touch message around one urgent problem only. Lead with a visible store signal plus one likely consequence, such as permission sprawl, excessive write access, chargeback exposure, or upcoming Shopify changes. Remove broad educational language and avoid asking prospects to explain their whole process. Test subject lines tied to urgency and specificity. If email underperforms, pair every prospect with LinkedIn profile visits, connection requests, and short follow-up messages.

FIRST CONVERSIONS TO BETA OR PILOT

## 1-2 beta review starts or serious pilot conversations by Day 30

Measure whether any qualified prospect moves beyond interest into an actual evaluation of the service. For DarkShepherd, this could be a free beta review, discounted pilot discussion, or a serious onboarding conversation around the setup fee and monthly monitoring. At this stage, the founder needs evidence of willingness to engage with the real offer, even if not yet full paid conversion. One or two serious pilot starts in the first month would be a strong signal for a manual, trust-heavy B2B service with no existing case studies.

> **If below target:** Reduce commitment friction. Time-box the beta to 3-5 brands, make the founder-led nature explicit, and clarify what the prospect receives: initial review, flagged risks, recommendations, and merchant-controlled decisions. If interest exists but nobody converts, the likely issue is offer packaging. Simplify pricing

discussion, emphasize limited early access, and ask for feedback/testimonial exchange instead of forcing immediate paid commitment.

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT AND AUDIENCE BUILDING

### By Day 30, publish at least 10 LinkedIn posts, leave 20 meaningful comments, gain 10-20 relevant new connections or followers from the target ecosystem, and generate at least 5 direct engagement signals such as comments, DMs, or checklist requests

Measure whether the founder is building visible credibility in a category that requires education. Community engagement matters because DarkShepherd is not selling into an already well-understood budget line; the founder has to teach the market and earn trust before prospects will book calls. Given limited time and an early-stage brand, the goal is not viral reach. The goal is repeated visibility among Shopify Plus apparel operators and adjacent partners, plus enough interaction to sharpen messaging and create warm opportunities.

**If below target:** Make posts more concrete and less abstract. Use simple formats: one misconception, one risk example, one checklist item, one consequence. Ask easy-to-answer questions or use polls. Comment on existing conversations where ecommerce leaders already discuss app overload, fraud, chargebacks, checkout issues, or Shopify changes. If organic engagement remains weak, repurpose posts into direct outreach assets and invite people to the briefing instead of waiting for inbound attention.

## 10 Advice — Do Things That Don't Scale

MILLION LABS ADVICE · YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS PLAYBOOK

## Do Things That Don't Scale. On Purpose.

1

### Start outreach the day you launch.

Don't wait for the platform to be perfect. Don't wait until you feel ready. You won't. The first listing teaches you more than six months of building in isolation.

Day one — no excuses

2

### Test 2-3 channels. No more.

Small bets. See what gets a response. £50-100 per channel max in the first 30 days. Spreading across 6 channels means you learn nothing about any of them.

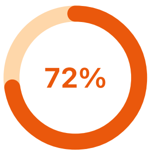
Data over gut feeling

3

### Own the one channel that works.

Double down on data, not instinct. 90% of early growth comes from one channel. Once you find it — Facebook groups, FSBO DMs, Nextdoor — master it completely before you expand.

Master it. Then expand.




of founders wait 6+ months before starting outreach. Don't wait until you feel ready. You won't. The platform doesn't need to be perfect — your first seller listing will teach you more than any deck.